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Fuelling The Pursuit Of Technology Knowledge

Cover Feature

Power 2 The People

Can piracy via P2P be stopped? Should it?

Robert Sovereign-Smith

Peer to peer (P2P) has been around for a long time now. Big software, music and movie corporations are against the piracy it fosters, users love it and pirates thrive on the notoriety it brings them. In our networked society, P2P accounts for the majority of the chit-chat (data transfer) globally. Studies have revealed that P2P networks, especially BitTorrent, accounts for over half the bandwidth used globally; so much so that standard Web surfing (HTTP) is nowhere in the same league.

So what's behind all the exabytes of data that's changed hard drives across the globe? Why is P2P so popular, and how will it change the future of the Net?

A Little History

Traditionally, the Internet is based on servers and clients. Thinkdigit.com resides on a server, which "serves" up files and content to anyone who wants it (the clients). The interface used by the clients to get this information is a Web browser, such as Internet Explorer, Firefox, Opera, etc. The data transfer protocol is called Hyper Text Transfer Protocol (HTTP), and remains the most popular usage of the Internet. Whether it's you hitting Google to find something, checking your e-mail, or browsing through a company Web site, you're using the Internet in the traditional way it was made for.

Now, somewhere along the line, people discovered that if so many people were online, all at once, perhaps there should be a way to talk to one another—a programmer somewhere said in a not-



Illustration Chaitanya Surpur